Four Tracker – User Manual

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Four Tracker is a 4-channel sample tracker in the style of ProTracker and FastTracker 2, built for playing live: you switch between patterns with the keys of a MIDI keyboard while the music keeps running. It runs as a standalone Windows program and as a VST2 and VST3 plugin, in 32-bit and 64-bit.

This manual is for anyone getting started with the program. Button and page names are written exactly as they appear on screen.

Getting started

Run **Four Tracker.exe** from the `dist\64-bit` folder and the built-in demo song is ready to play.

Standalone program

1. Double-click `Four Tracker.exe` (64-bit), or the one in `dist\32-bit` on an older PC.
2. If Windows shows "Windows protected your PC", click **More info** → **Run anyway**. The program is not signed.
3. Open the **MIDI / AUDIO** tab, choose your sound card and tick your MIDI keyboard.
4. Press **C-2** on the keyboard, or **Enter** on the computer keyboard, to start the demo song.

As a plugin in a music program (host)

Format	File	Copy to
VST3, 64-bit	`Four Tracker.vst3`	`C:\Program Files\Common Files\VST3`
VST3, 32-bit	`Four Tracker.vst3` (from `dist\32-bit`)	`C:\Program Files (x86)\Common Files\VST3`
VST2	`Four Tracker.dll`	The VST folder your host scans

Use the version that matches the host: a 32-bit program can only load 32-bit plugins. Load Four Tracker as an **instrument** on a track, and route your MIDI keyboard to that track.

First start

- The standalone program always starts with the demo song. Your MIDI and audio settings are remembered.

- The first time, it creates `Documents\Four Tracker\Demo` with **Demo Song.ftm** and the demo sounds as WAV files.
- As a plugin, the song is saved inside your host project and comes back when you open the project.

The screen

The screen has three fixed parts: the title bar at the top, the control row below it and the tabs at the bottom. The middle area changes with the tab you pick.

Title bar shows the status at the far right, for example `PLAY 00:01A>01`: pattern 00 is playing at row 1A, and pattern 01 is waiting to take over. It also shows EDIT/JAM, octave and step. Short messages such as "SAVED" appear here for a few seconds.

Control row

Field	What it does
PATTERN + PREV/NEXT	Picks pattern 00–3F. While playing, the chosen pattern is queued.
INSTRUMENT + PREV/NEXT	Picks the instrument (01–10) that the keys play and write with. Its name is shown on the right.
LOOP ON/OFF	ON: the pattern starts over when it ends. OFF: playback stops at the last row.
SPEED	Ticks per row (1–31). Lower = faster rows. Default 6.
BPM	Tempo (32–255). Default 125.
OCTAVE	Octave of the lower key row, 0–7 (default 4). Set it to 2 and Z writes C-2. F1 / F2 change it too.
EDIT	Red = the keys write notes into the pattern. Grey = the keys only play the sound.
HEX / DEC	Shows row and pattern numbers in hex (00–3F) or decimal (00–63).

Change a value box by dragging up/down with the mouse, with the mouse wheel, or by double-clicking and typing a number. Hold Shift for big steps.

Tabs at the bottom

Tab	Contents
INSTRUMENTS	Load samples and set up instruments
SAMPLE EDIT	Trim, loop and process samples
SONG / PATTERN	Start/stop, pattern length, new/load/save module
BLOCK	Cut, copy and paste tracks and whole patterns
MIDI / AUDIO	MIDI keys, switch mode and sound card
(track icon, far right)	The main view with the four channels and the pattern

In the main view, each channel (CH1–CH4) has a small waveform, a level meter and the VOL, PAN and PITCH boxes. Click a channel name to mute it (MUTE).

Playing live with a MIDI keyboard

C-2 starts and stops playback, and each key from **C#2** upwards picks one pattern.

Key	Does
C-2 (MIDI 36)	Start / stop
C#2	Pattern 00
D-2	Pattern 01
D#2	Pattern 02
E-2	Pattern 03
… and so on	up to pattern 3F (63)

- **While stopped:** a pattern key picks which pattern C-2 will start. Pattern 00 is picked at start-up.
- **While playing:** a pattern key switches pattern without restarting. When the switch happens depends on the switch mode below.
- Pressing the key of the pattern that is already playing cancels a waiting switch.
- The START/STOP PATTERN buttons on the SONG / PATTERN page and **Enter** on the computer keyboard do the same as C-2.
- The start/stop key can be moved on the MIDI / AUDIO page (LEARN). The pattern keys move with it.

Switch modes (PATTERN SWITCH)

Example: pattern 00 has reached row 10, and you press D-2 for pattern 01.

Mode	What happens	Good for
NEXT ROW (LEGATO) – default	Switches on the next row and carries on from row 11 of pattern 01. Notes that are ringing keep ringing.	Quick, seamless switches
NEXT BEAT (LEGATO)	As above, but waits for the next beat (every 4th row: 12, 16, 20 …).	Switches that always land in time
END OF PATTERN	Pattern 00 plays to its last row, then pattern 01 starts at row 0.	Safe switches at whole phrases
RESTART AT ROW 0	Switches at once and starts pattern 01 from the top.	A hard cut as an effect

For live use, NEXT ROW or NEXT BEAT are the most natural.

Writing patterns

Turn **EDIT** on (the button turns red, or press Space), place the cursor and play notes on the computer keyboard.

The pattern

A pattern has 4 channels and 64 rows by default (1–256, set on the SONG / PATTERN page). Each cell reads `NOTE INS CCPP`, for example `C-4 01 0C40`:

Part	Example	Meaning
NOTE	`C-4`	The note. `---` = nothing, `===` = note off. C-4 plays a sample at its own pitch.
INS	`01`	The instrument (01–10). `00` = keep the instrument already on the channel.
CC	`0C`	Effect number (see Effect commands).
PP	`40`	Effect parameter, in hex.

The row numbers on every 4th row are brighter (a beat), and every 16th row is shaded (a bar).

Notes from the computer keyboard

The keys are laid out like a piano over two octaves:

Keys	Notes
`Z S X D C V G B H N J M`	C, C#, D, D#, E, F, F#, G, G#, A, A#, B (lower octave)
`Q 2 W 3 E R 5 T 6 Y 7 U I`	C to C of the octave above
`1` or `` ` ``	Note off (`===`)

- **F1 / F2** (or the OCTAVE box) move the octave down/up, from 0 to 7, so notes can go all the way down to C-0. **F6 / F7** change the edit step: how many rows the cursor jumps after each entry.
- With EDIT off, the keys just play the selected instrument. A sample without a loop plays to its end; a looped sample loops while the key is held. Holding a key does not retrigger the sound.
- In the instrument and effect columns, type hex digits `0–9` and `A–F`.

Moving and editing

- Arrow keys move the cursor; Tab / Shift+Tab jump between channels; PgUp/PgDn move 16 rows; Home/End go to the first/last row.
- **Delete** clears the field (or the marked area), **Insert** inserts an empty row in the channel, **Backspace** deletes a row.
- **Ctrl+Z** undoes and **Ctrl+Y** redoes pattern edits.
- Click a cell with the mouse to move the cursor there; drag to mark an area.

Effect commands

The effect column uses the FastTracker 2 numbers; 00–0F are the classic ProTracker commands that OctaMED also uses. `x` and `y` are the two hex digits of the parameter, `xx` is the whole byte. A parameter of 00 on most slides and portamentos reuses the last value.

CC	Effect	Parameter
00	Arpeggio	xy: plays note, note+x, note+y semitones in turn
01	Portamento up	xx: speed
02	Portamento down	xx: speed
03	Tone portamento	xx: speed of the slide to the new note

CC	Effect	Parameter
04	Vibrato	x: speed, y: depth
05	Tone portamento + volume slide	xy: as 0A
06	Vibrato + volume slide	xy: as 0A
07	Tremolo	x: speed, y: depth
08	Set panning	xx: 00 left, 80 centre, FF right
09	Sample offset	xx: start at xx × 256 frames
0A	Volume slide	x: up, y: down (per tick)
0B	Jump to pattern	xx: pattern number
0C	Set volume	xx: 00–40
0D	Pattern break	xy: continue at row xy (decimal)
0E 1x / 2x	Fine portamento up / down	x: amount
0E 4x / 7x	Vibrato / tremolo waveform	0 sine, 1 ramp, 2 square
0E 5x	Set finetune	x: 0–F, 8 = none
0E 6x	Pattern loop	0: set loop start, x: repeat x times
0E 8x	Set panning, coarse	x: 0 left – F right
0E 9x	Retrigger	x: every x ticks
0E Ax / Bx	Fine volume up / down	x: amount
0E Cx	Note cut	x: at tick x
0E Dx	Note delay	x: start the row x ticks late
0E Ex	Pattern delay	x: hold the row x extra rows
0F	Speed / BPM	01–1F: speed, 20–FF: BPM
10	Global volume (Gxx)	xx: 00–40
11	Global volume slide (Hxy)	x: up, y: down
14	Key off (Kxx)	xx: at tick xx
19	Panning slide (Pxy)	x: right, y: left

CC	Effect	Parameter
1B	Multi retrigger (Rxy)	x: volume change, y: interval in ticks
1D	Tremor (Txy)	x+1 ticks on, y+1 ticks off
21 1x / 2x	Extra fine portamento up / down	x: amount

Example: `C-4 01 0C20` plays instrument 01 at half volume; `--- 00 0F08` sets the speed to 8 on that row.

Instruments page

There are 16 instrument slots, 01–10 (hex). Pick a slot in the list on the left or in the INSTRUMENT SLOT grid, then press **LOAD** to put a sample in it.

Loading samples

- **LOAD** opens a file dialog. It remembers the last folder you loaded from until the program is closed, on both this page and SAMPLE EDIT.
- Select several files at once to fill consecutive slots, starting at the selected one.
- You can also drag audio files from Windows onto the window.
- Supported formats: WAV, AIFF, FLAC, Ogg Vorbis and MP3, mono or stereo, up to 2 minutes. Amiga samples from ProTracker and OctaMED disks also load: IFF 8SVX (.iff, .8svx, including Fibonacci-compressed and stereo files, with their loop and name; they always load at full volume, like in ProTracker) and raw signed 8-bit samples (.raw, .smp, .sam, .snd or no extension), which are played at 16574 Hz like ProTracker's C-3.
- **DISCARD** empties the selected slot.
- Double-click a slot to hear it. With EDIT off, the computer keys also play the selected instrument.
- Double-click the name field at the top to rename the instrument.

Settings

Setting	Range	What it does
VOLUME	0–64	The instrument's own volume
TRANSPOSE	−48 to +48	Shifts the pitch in semitones
FINE TUNE	−128 to +127	Fine pitch, 1/128 of a semitone per step

Setting	Range	What it does
LOOP	ON/OFF	Repeats the loop area set on SAMPLE EDIT while the note plays
PING PONG	ON/OFF	The loop plays forwards and backwards in turn
REVERSE	ON/OFF	Plays the whole sample backwards without changing the file

SAMPLE INFO shows length (frames), sample rate, bit depth, channels and size. The bar under the settings shows the file the sample came from.

Sample Edit page

Sample Edit shows the selected instrument's waveform, where you set the playable part, the loop and make destructive edits.

Markers in the waveform

- **S** and **E** (start and end) set which part of the sample is played. Drag them, or type values in START / END.
- The light area marked **LOOP** is the loop. Drag its edges, or drag the bar at the top to move the whole loop. LOOP START / LOOP END take exact values.
- Click to place the cursor (CURRENT POS). Drag to select an area. Shift+click extends the selection.
- While a sound plays, a white line shows where it is.

Buttons

Button	What it does
SET START / SET END	Moves S or E to the cursor
SET LOOP	Makes the selection the loop (or cursor → end) and turns LOOP on
PLAY LOOP	Plays only the loop, until pressed again
LOOP MODE: FORWARD / REVERSE	The loop runs forwards, or backwards
CUT / COPY / PASTE	Cuts or copies the selection; pastes at the cursor
FADE IN / FADE OUT	Fades the selection, or the whole sample if nothing is selected
NORMALIZE	Raises the level so the loudest point is at full scale

Button	What it does
REVERSE	Turns the selection (or whole sample) backwards for good
ZOOM +/−, FIT, SCROLL	Zooms in, out, shows all, and scrolls. Ctrl+mouse wheel also zooms.

You can also play the sample from the computer keys on this page: hold a key and a looped sample keeps looping until you let go. CUT, PASTE, FADE, NORMALIZE and REVERSE change the sample itself; there is no undo for these, so save a module first.

Song / Pattern page

This page starts and stops playback and saves your work as a module: one `.ftm` file with all patterns and all samples.

Button	What it does
START PATTERN	Starts the selected pattern from row 0
STOP PATTERN	Stops playback
NEW MODULE	Asks: **Empty** (clears every pattern and sample), **Demo song** (loads the built-in demo) or **Cancel**
LOAD MODULE	Opens a `.ftm` module, or an old `.ftps` pattern set
SAVE MODULE	Saves everything to a `.ftm` file
PATTERN LENGTH	Rows in the current pattern, 1–256 (default 64)

What a module holds: all 64 patterns, all samples, instrument settings, speed, BPM, loop and the channel mixer. MIDI mapping and sound card settings are not part of it; they belong to the program.

- Old `.ftps` pattern sets hold patterns only. Loading one keeps the samples you already have.
- You can drag a `.ftm` file onto the window to load it.
- LOAD and SAVE start in `Documents\Four Tracker`. The demo is in `Documents\Four Tracker\Demo`, with its sounds as WAV files in `Samples`.
- **The standalone program does not remember the song when it closes** – it always starts with the demo. Save a module before closing. As a plugin, the song is stored in the host project.

Block page

F3 cuts, F4 copies and F5 pastes, as in ProTracker: with **Shift** it works on one track (channel), with **Ctrl** on the whole block.

Keys	Button	Works on
Shift+F3 / F4 / F5	CUT / COPY / PASTE TRACK	The channel the cursor is in, all rows
Ctrl+F3 / F4 / F5	CUT / COPY / PASTE BLOCK	The whole pattern: all 4 channels, all rows (64 rows = 4 bars). Paste also takes the pattern length.
Ctrl+X / C / V	–	A marked area (Shift+arrows or mouse drag)

To make a variation of pattern 00: stand in 00 and press **Ctrl+F4**, switch to 01, press **Ctrl+F5**, and edit the copy. **Ctrl+Z** undoes a paste. The buttons on this page do the same as the keys; in some hosts Ctrl+F4 is taken by the host, so use the button there.

MIDI / Audio page

The left half sets up the MIDI keys, the right half the sound. These settings are remembered between sessions and are not part of a module.

MIDI IN

Setting	What it does
START/STOP KEY	The key that starts/stops (default C-2). The pattern keys start one key above it. Type a note name (C-2, C#3) or a MIDI number.
LEARN	Press LEARN, then a key on your MIDI keyboard: that key becomes start/stop.
MIDI CHANNEL	OMNI listens on all channels, or pick 1–16.
MIDI START/STOP	ON: MIDI Start/Stop messages from a sequencer or clock also start and stop playback.
PATTERN SWITCH	When a new pattern takes over (see Playing live).

The black box shows which key does what, and highlights the last key you pressed – a quick way to check that the keyboard is reaching the program.

AUDIO

- **MASTER**: overall output level, 0–100.
- **Standalone:** choose the driver type (ASIO, WASAPI or DirectSound), the output device, sample rate and buffer size, and tick which MIDI inputs to use. ASIO appears only if the program was built with the ASIO SDK. A smaller buffer gives a faster response to the keys but needs more from the computer.
- **Plugin:** the host owns the sound card and buffer. **FOLLOW HOST TEMPO** ON makes the tracker use the host's BPM instead of its own.

Keyboard shortcuts

Keys	Action
Enter	Start / stop
Esc	Stop
Space	EDIT on / off
Z S X D C V … / Q 2 W 3 E …	Play or write notes (two octaves)
1 or `	Note off (note column)
0–9, A–F	Instrument and effect digits
F1 / F2	Octave down / up
F6 / F7	Edit step down / up
Numpad + / –	Next / previous instrument
Arrows, Tab, Shift+Tab, PgUp, PgDn, Home, End	Move the cursor
Shift + arrows	Mark an area
Delete / Insert / Backspace	Clear field / insert row / delete row
Ctrl+X / C / V	Cut / copy / paste the marked area
Shift+F3 / F4 / F5	Cut / copy / paste the track
Ctrl+F3 / F4 / F5	Cut / copy / paste the whole block
Ctrl+A	Mark the whole pattern
Ctrl+Z / Ctrl+Y	Undo / redo

Keys	Action
F9 / F10 / F11 / F12	Tracks / Instruments / Sample Edit / MIDI-Audio page

Troubleshooting

Problem	Try this
No sound	On MIDI / AUDIO, check the output device and that MASTER is above 0. Check that no channel says MUTE and that VOL is above 0.
The MIDI keyboard does nothing	On MIDI / AUDIO, tick the keyboard under the MIDI inputs (standalone). Press a key: LAST KEY should change. Check that MIDI CHANNEL is OMNI or the keyboard's channel.
C-2 is not where I expect	Keyboards number octaves differently. Use LEARN and press the key you want as start/stop.
Typing does not write notes	Turn EDIT on (red), and put the cursor in the note column.
Sound crackles or lags	Choose ASIO if you have it, or raise the buffer size on MIDI / AUDIO.
My song was gone after restarting	The standalone program always starts with the demo song. Save with SAVE MODULE before closing, and load the `.ftm` file again.
The plugin does not show up in the host	Check that you copied the right version (32-bit host needs the 32-bit plugin), into the folder the host scans, and run a plugin rescan. Older hosts may only support VST2 (`Four Tracker.dll`).
Ctrl+F4 closes a window in the host	The host uses that key. Use the CUT/COPY/PASTE BLOCK buttons on the BLOCK page.
"Windows protected your PC"	Click More info → Run anyway. The program is not signed.